POWER LOOMS LIFTED WEAVER CASTE MEN IN KARATTUR FROM POVERTY, MANY OF WHOM STARTED CINEMA HALLS WITH THEIR GAINS

screen idols, about what an MGR truly meant to them at the personal and political levels. Murugan maintains a dry sense of humour throughout, like in the fourth essay, which ends on an ironic note. Murugan informs the reader that, eventually, he started helping his father run his soda stall at the theatre, and that this was his first real job. And in the very next line, we are told that the first film the boy-Murugan saw during his time at the soda stall was *Per Solla Oru Pillai*, i.e. 'a son to carry on the family name' in Tamil.

Tamil Nadu is a state that takes its cinema more seriously than most, and books like *The Land and the Shadows* can help you understand why that is the case. ■

—Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS ▼

Art and Artifice

A LEADING GALLERIST'S FICTIONALISED TAKE ON THE INCESTUOUS WORLD OF INDIAN ART

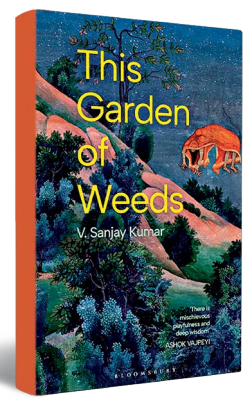
The contemporary art world thrives on a curious paradox. It presents itself as a realm of cultivated taste and aesthetic refinement, yet behind the gallery walls lies a dense network of ambition, patronage and market calculation. In *This Garden of Weeds*, V. Sanjay Kumar turns that ecosystem into the subject of a lively and observant novel.

At the centre of the story are Salil Gupta, a Delhi businessman eager to enter the rarefied world of Mumbai's contemporary art scene, and his daughter Nupur, whose ambitions lie in curating and shaping artistic discourse. Their attempt to gain a foothold in this tightly guarded cultural sphere eventually takes the form of an ambitious experiment: a reality show-style art competition with a lavish prize that promises to discover new talent. The initiative draws them into a milieu populated by artists, dealers, critics and collectors, each navigating their own claims to recognition and authority. The novel unfolds through a wide cast and shifting perspectives, gradually revealing the ambitions, alliances and rivalries that shape this world.

The title offers a fitting metaphor. A garden suggests cultivation, order and aesthetic harmony, while weeds represent the unruly and the unexpected. Kumar's fictional art world contains both. Creativity and sincerity coexist with vanity, rivalry and market pressures, producing a cultural environment that is as competitive as it is creative.

If the satire occasionally broadens into caricature, the novel still captures the rhythms and contradictions of a scene rarely explored in Indian fiction. *This Garden of Weeds* does so with wit and a discerning eye for its vanities. ■

—Nikhil Sardana



THIS GARDEN OF WEEDS
By V. Sanjay Kumar
BLOOMSBURY
₹599; 288 pages

thoughts on love, sex, and desire—the anthology does not categorise intimacy.

Instead, it assembles messy, searching, often contradictory voices that speak to the many ways people experience love and sex. What emerges is not a neat portrait of modern Indian desire but something far more interesting: a textured landscape of lived realities where vulnerability coexists with confusion, and pleasure with doubt.

Across 50-odd pieces—essays, poems, stories and anonymous accounts—the book traces a wide emotional range: sexual discovery, disappointing encounters, desire within long-term relationships, queer experiences and moments that resist easy naming. Some are understated; others are more unsettling. None attempt to stand in for anything larger than themselves.

ACROSS 50-ODD ESSAYS, STORIES AND POEMS, THE VOLUME TRACES A WIDE RANGE OF DESIRE THAT OFTEN RESISTS EASY NAMING

Vohra's editorial approach holds the volume together. The writing is intentionally uneven, which works in its favour. These are not polished literary exercises but candid articulations that are sometimes hesitant, sometimes startlingly clear. The focus is not on craft as much as on the act of speaking.

There is also a distinctly local quality to the language and sensibility. Instead of leaning on the language of global sexual discourse, the book locates itself firmly within an Indian context, making desire sound specific and unforced. The collection leaves behind not a conclusion but a feeling: that desire, in all its uncertainty, does not need to be resolved to be understood. ■

—Poulomi Das